

Pergularia extensa (Asclepiadaceae)

Pergularia

Description Perennial climber with broad oval leaves and small greenish-white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation *Pergularia* is native to India. Its aerial parts are gathered throughout the year.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents *Pergularia* contains a resin, bitter principles, and plant sterols.

Medicinal Actions & Uses *Pergularia* is thought to have bitter, expectorant, diuretic, and laxative properties, and is employed in several ways in Indian herbal medicine. It is prescribed as a treatment for bronchitis and asthma. *Pergularia* is also used as a means to curtail heavy menstrual or non-menstrual uterine bleeding. Juice from the leaves may be applied to relieve the pain and swelling of cysts and rheumatic joints.

Petroselinum crispum (Apiaceae)

Parsley

Description Annual herb growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has an erect stem, bright green compound smooth or crinkled leaves, small white flowers growing in clusters, and small ribbed seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Parsley is native to Europe and the eastern Mediterranean. Today it is rarely found in the wild, but is cultivated throughout the world as a nutritious salad herb. The leaves may be picked from spring to autumn, and the seeds are gathered when just ripe.

Parts Used Leaves, root, seeds.

Constituents Parsley contains a volatile oil (including about 20% myristicin, about 18% apiol, and many other terpenes), flavonoids, phthalides, coumarins (including bergapten), vitamins A, C, and E, and high levels of iron. The flavonoids are anti-inflammatory and antioxidant. Myristicin and apiol have diuretic properties. The volatile oil relieves cramping pain and flatulence, and is a strong uterine stimulant.

History & Folklore Parsley was known in ancient Greece and Rome—but more as a diuretic, digestive tonic, and menstrual stimulant than as a salad herb. In Rome, parsley was associated with the goddess Persephone, queen of the underworld, and was used in funeral ceremonies. Parsley was introduced to Britain in 1548.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The fresh leaves are highly nutritious and can be considered a natural vitamin and mineral supplement in their own right. The seeds have a much stronger diuretic action than the leaves, and may be substituted for celery seeds (*Apium graveolens*, p. 64) in the

treatment of gout, rheumatism, and arthritis. Both plants act by encouraging the flushing out of waste products from the inflamed joints, and the waste's subsequent elimination via the kidneys. Parsley root is taken as a treatment for flatulence, cystitis, and rheumatic conditions. Parsley is also valued as a promoter of menstruation, being helpful both in stimulating a delayed period and in relieving menstrual pain.

Cautions Parsley is a safe herb at normal dosage and consumption levels, but excessive quantities of the seeds are toxic. Do not take the seeds during pregnancy or if suffering from kidney disease.

Peumus boldus (Apiaceae)

Boldo

Description Strongly aromatic multibranched evergreen shrub or tree growing to 20 ft (6 m). Has egg-shaped leathery leaves with a lemony scent, clusters of white or yellow bell-shaped flowers, and small yellow berries.

Habitat & Cultivation

Boldo is native to Chile and Peru, and has become naturalized in the Mediterranean region and the West Coast of North America. It grows on dry sunny slopes and in mountain pastures in the Andes, where it is widely cultivated. The leaves are gathered throughout the year.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Boldo contains 0.7% isoquinoline alkaloids (including boldine), as well as a volatile oil and flavonoids.

History & Folklore Boldo is a valued remedy in Latin American herbal medicine and is used by the Araucanian people in Chile as a tonic.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Boldo stimulates liver activity and bile flow and is chiefly valued as a remedy for gallstones and liver or gallbladder pain. It is normally taken for a few weeks at a time, either as a tincture or infusion. Boldo is also a mild urinary antiseptic and demulcent and may be taken for infections such as cystitis.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy. This herb is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.



Dried leaves

Pfaffia paniculata (Amaranthaceae)

Suma, Brazilian Ginseng

Description Climbing perennial with a thick rootstock, growing up through rainforest trees into the forest canopy.

Habitat & Cultivation Suma is native to rainforests of South America, from Venezuela to southern Brazil.

Parts Used Root.

Constituents Suma contains triterpene saponins (paffosides), sterols (including beta-ecdysone), and minerals (including significant levels of germanium).

History & Folklore Suma has been used by the people of the Amazon rainforest from the earliest times for conditions as varied as wound healing, diabetes, and cancer. Also taken for its aphrodisiac qualities, suma has become a popular herbal medicine in Brazil, where it is known as *para todo* ("for all"), or Brazilian ginseng.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Suma has many medicinal applications, most centred around three areas of activity: as a hormonal and glandular tonic, as an immune stimulant and detoxifying agent, and in cancer prevention and treatment. Suma is perhaps best known as a male sexual tonic, but it is equally effective for women and has value in treating menstrual and menopausal problems. Suma root enhances nonspecific immunity and has a role to play in treating chronic infection and lowered immune resistance.

Research Research into suma suggests that it can be useful in cancer prevention and treatment; several of the paffosides have been shown to prevent tumor growth in laboratory conditions. The paffosides are chemically similar to the ginsenosides found in ginseng (*Panax ginseng*, p. 118), and, like ginseng, suma's acclaimed value as an aphrodisiac appears to have a scientific basis. Male rats with depressed sexual function were observed to become more sexually active on being given a suma extract.

Cautions Avoid taking suma during pregnancy and while breastfeeding.

Phaseolus vulgaris (Fabaceae)

French Bean, Haricot Bean

Description Slender-stemmed, annual climber growing to 13 ft (4 m). Has pointed oval leaflets, curly tendrils, clusters of white or lilac flowers, and a beanpod containing kidney-shaped seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation French beans are thought to have originated from South America. Today, varieties are cultivated all over the world. The ripe beans are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Beanpods, beans.

Constituents French beans contain lectins, saponins, flavonoids, allantoin, amino acids, and sugars.

History & Folklore French beans have been used since antiquity to treat diabetes. In *A Modern Herbal* (1931), Mrs. Grieve records that "because